

America's 250th Birthday - The Black 4th in Philadelphia

By Meredith Edlow | Jul 8

During Philadelphia's 2026 Semiquincentennial celebrations, community organizers created events "highlighting people from North and South Philly, on a necessary trip through the American story rooted in a truer history of the country."

The week featured several significant moments addressing historical accuracy:

The President's House Commemoration

Federal authorities had removed informational panels about enslaved people at the President's House site on Independence Mall. On July 4th, the Avenging The Ancestors Coalition and President's House Coalition held a memorial event honoring "the 9 enslaved" at the site, preserving this history amid attempts at erasure.

Nikole Hannah-Jones Conversation

During the city's July 4th festival, journalist Nikole Hannah-Jones (author of the 1619 Project) engaged in conversation hosted by Lorene Cary, discussing "why erasing history would be so important to an authoritarian government."

Quaker Anti-Slavery History

The Arch Street Meeting House exhibited a 1688 anti-slavery document signed by Germantown Quakers who challenged slavery in their community.

Joe Frazier Statue Relocation

A statue of legendary boxer Joe Frazier (whose gym operated in North Philadelphia) was relocated to a prominent position near the Philadelphia Museum of Art on June 29, 2026.

July 4th Celebrations

Philadelphia held a star-studded concert featuring performances by Jill Scott, Meek Mill, The Roots, and others, hosted by Wanda Sykes. A drone light show entertained crowds at the National Constitution Center.

Images

- The "Annual Independence Day Gathering, Freedom Truth and Remembrance" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_08fda530e92b49979a904c8748b9556f~mv2.jpg
- Michelle Flamer at the gathering — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_83c4f88cb4144294a7ea57540a21ec7b~mv2.jpg
- Philadelphia officials at the gathering — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_5a1f7986c3c4473ab07c32bbd63840d1~mv2.jpg
- City Council President Kenyatta Johnson — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_89a9be872cce4872b026146e98ef8e7d~mv2.jpg
- Lorene Cary and Nikole Hannah-Jones — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_8cabdd717b944ca2912f968727db70d9~mv2.jpg
- Event attendees with Hannah-Jones — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_370bb0c6570b49d59e4f3c492a7f1bda~mv2.jpg
- Arch Street Meeting House exhibits (2 images) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_9c4ed635b08746a99c99f7311206de56~mv2.jpg; https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_9ad869b531a642d882a9ae4c46f7933e~mv2.jpg
- Joe Frazier statue unveiling crowd — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_66ccdaf5b0314b69bec51be4cde5416d~mv2.jpg
- Boxer Bernard Hopkins — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_930cc9c234914aac847fc3d2a861cbad~mv2.jpg
- Judge Jacqui Frazier Lyde — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_25c51d1eecb84ef98367d077aeb999b6~mv2.jpg
- Parade floats (3 images) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_c44efab7d0f44a56a3d72ecb15f4b84e~mv2.jpg; https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_0ff285d8a5a64a9c9aa0a8ecbd3ea3f6~mv2.jpg; https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_2a14db814ef248f2b4c788b533fd2c82~mv2.jpg
- Independence Illumination Drone Show — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_d06c644d6a77445f8f13f4c09069254d~mv2.jpg
- Visitor at President's House — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/fcbf59_b60deb90f296411c9c554ec299dcf11c~mv2.jpg
- Concert performance images (multiple) — various URLs from fcbf59 collection

